

Chapter 44

William's head spun.

It wasn't possible.

His father.

Vinnie.

Alive.

Bearded.

His face worn by twenty years that William had never shared with him.

He stood only yards away, surrounded by thousands of people, yet somehow entirely alone.

His eyes...

William's stomach turned.

They weren't blue.

They weren't even human.

Cold.

Black.

Bottomless.

Something inside them seemed to move.

William instinctively took half a step backward.

Antonio did the opposite.

“VINNIE!”

Without hesitation he sprinted toward him, arms already opening for an embrace.

“Brother!”

The cloaked man barely acknowledged him.

One hand moved almost lazily.

A flick.

Antonio's body left the ground as though he weighed nothing at all.

He struck the earth hard, rolled twice, and crashed into one of the rope stanchions before coming to an unmoving stop.

The audience gasped.

Several applauded.

They thought it was choreography.

The cloaked man never looked in Antonio's direction.

"I'm afraid..."

His voice carried effortlessly across the hillside.

"...Vinnie is long gone."

He smiled.

It was not a human smile.

"It took me twenty years..."

"...but eventually I persuaded this miserable body to surrender."

He slowly spread his arms.

"I have been imprisoned."

His gaze settled once more upon William.

"But today..."

"...I shall finally be free."

He stepped forward.

"And soon..."

"...I'll have a new body."

Rocky's expression changed instantly.

Recognition.

Horror.

Memory.

His lips barely moved.

“Farloh...”

He whispered the name like an ancient curse.

Then he charged.

Years of anger.

Years of questions.

Years of grief.

All poured into a single desperate sprint.

Farloh never turned his head.

Another careless movement of his hand.

Rocky flew sideways as though struck by an invisible freight train.

His body slammed against one of the great stones.

He struggled.

He couldn't move.

It was as though unseen hands pinned him there.

Farloh never took his eyes off William.

“You have no idea what you are.”

His voice became almost fatherly.

“When we found you...”

“...no one understood your inheritance.”

“No one...”

“...except me.”

William couldn't breathe.

“I had been betrayed.”

“Jasmine stole you.”

“She hid you.”

“The pathetic Saltines believed they could keep you from me.”

A slow smile crossed his face.

“But they misunderstood.”

“They believed she betrayed me.”

“They were wrong.”

His smile widened.

“She was waiting.”

“Patiently.”

Farloh turned toward Claire.

His voice softened.

“Jasmine.”

He extended his hand.

“Come to me.”

Claire looked at William.

His face had gone completely pale.

His entire world was collapsing in front of him.

Very slowly...

She released his hand.

Walked forward.

And stopped beside Farloh.

William stared.

No.

No...

No...

Farloh nodded approvingly.

“There.”

“My family...”

“...together again.”

He looked back to William.

“Come.”

“The transfer will be painless.”

“When this body dies...”

“...I shall finally become who I was always meant to be.”

William heard nothing after that.

The world lost its color.

The brilliant green fields.

The blue sky.

Claire’s sweater.

Everything faded into lifeless shades of gray.

Claire...

Was Jasmine?

His parents...

Had lied?

The Saltines...

Had lied?

His entire life...

A lie.

He looked toward Antonio.

Unconscious.

Rocky.

Trapped.

Claire.

Standing beside the monster.

He was alone.

Entirely...

Alone.

Farloh stepped closer.

“William.”

“The time has come.”

“The process will be compl—”

The sentence ended with a wet gasp.

His eyes widened.

He looked down.

A knife protruded from beneath his ribs.

The blade disappeared almost to its handle.

For a heartbeat...

No one moved.

Then Farloh collapsed to one knee.

Blood spread rapidly across the black cloak.

His breathing became ragged.

The knife slipped from Claire's fingers as he crumpled onto the grass.

She stood over him.

Her voice shook.

Not with fear.

With fury.

"I'm not Jasmine..."

She swallowed.

"...you son of a bitch."

"My name..."

She looked directly at William.

"...is Claire."

A breath.

"Claire Saltine."

Silence.

Rocky suddenly dropped to the ground as the unseen force holding him vanished.

Antonio groaned somewhere behind them.

Claire turned immediately.

She ran to William.

Not toward victory.

Toward him.

Instinctively.

Protectively.

She reached for his hand.

He pulled it away.

His voice was barely audible.

“Who...”

He looked into her eyes.

“...who are you?”

Her own eyes filled.

“It’s me.”

She reached for him again.

“William...”

“It’s me.”

“I’m sorry.”

“I didn’t know how else to get close enough.”

“I’m so sorry. I still had your knife and I just thought...”

William couldn’t answer.

He slowly walked past her.

Toward the fallen man.

Rocky arrived beside him.

Antonio, still rubbing the back of his head, staggered over a moment later.

Together...

The three men looked down.

The blackness was gone.

Vinnie's eyes...

Blue.

Peaceful.

Human.

His chest rose ever so slightly.

Rocky dropped to one knee and pressed his ear against Vinnie's chest.

Several endless seconds passed.

Then he looked up.

"I think..."

His voice caught.

"I think he's alive."

He looked at the others.

"We've got to get him to a hospital."

Immediately."

Without another word Rocky carefully lifted Vinnie into his arms as though carrying a sleeping child.

The audience exploded into applause.

People stood.

Cheered.

Hundreds of phones rose into the air.

To them...

It had been the greatest historical performance they'd ever witnessed.

William walked beside Rocky, one hand wrapped tightly around Vinnie's.

Claire stayed beside William, refusing to let him face another step alone.

Antonio looked around at the cheering crowd.

He shrugged.

Then gave an exaggerated bow.

The applause somehow became even louder.

He shook hands with two delighted tourists on the way back toward the visitor center.

William barely noticed.

The green was gone.

The whispers were gone.

For the first time in his life...

The world felt wonderfully, beautifully quiet.

And somehow...

Wonderfully, beautifully right.

Mission Accomplished

